

CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

KINJARAPU RAM MOHAN NAIDU, 34

National General Secretary & Lok Sabha leader, TDP, Srikakulam

Accidental Politician

Politics, he says, was never an option for him. With a bachelor's degree in Electrical Engineering from Purdue and an MBA from Long Island (2011) universities in the US, he was working as a business development manager for an investment company in 2009. But the tragic death of his father, four-time MP and Telugu Desam Party parliamentary leader K. Yerran Naidu, in a road accident in November 2012 changed the course of his life. TDP chief N. Chandrababu Naidu put the young Ram Mohan in charge of his father's Srikakulam Lok Sabha constituency in 2013 on the eve of the 2014 parliamentary polls. He delivered, and how. Riding the sympathy wave for his father, the newbie politician defeated YSRC candidate Reddy Shanti by 127,572 votes. And there was no looking back.

"Personally, losing a father at that age felt like the end of the world," he says. "At the same time I was overwhelmed by the legacy my father had built in his 30-year political journey." He was exposed to Parliament and its working while Naidu Sr was Union rural development and employment minister between 1996 and 1998 and he was studying at Delhi Public School, RK Puram. But being in politics himself was a different proposition.

Inspired by his father's example, Ram Mohan spent his 31st birthday in December 2018 sitting on a hunger strike near the Mahatma Gandhi statue in Parliament, seeking Special Category Status for Andhra Pradesh.

He was back Parliament in 2019 despite the YSRC wave, though with a smaller margin of 6,653 votes. He takes the responsibility seriously, seldom missing a Lok Sabha session and eloquently presenting his state's concerns or his party's viewpoint on issues of national concern. No one was surprised when he became the youngest MP to win the Sansad Ratna Award in 2020.

A firm votary of providing youth the opportunity to participate in politics and giving them exposure to governance, he launched a Politics for Impact scheme in May 2018 inviting youth to intern for two months in his constituency. Eighteen students were picked out of the 201 students who applied from 130 colleges in 16 states for the internship.

"Srikakulam as a constituency has a lot of scope for development," says Ram Mohan. He has worked hard for the sanction of the six-laning of the National Highway through the district, a project worth Rs 2,000 crore. Other plans include completing all irrigation projects to provide irrigation water for two crops, creating healthy sources of employment to stem migration, and better health infrastructure. In May 2021, he launched an exclusive Covid-19 helpline for his constituency with information on doctors, hospitals and bed availability. ■

– Amarnath K. Menon

"India needs young, committed people. Ram Mohan manages a healthy balance between his constituency and his work in Parliament. Being fluent in Hindi, Telugu and English helps"

ASHOK GAJAPATHI RAJU
Former Union Civil Aviation Minister

DADDY DUTY In January 2021, Ram Mohan took nine days of paternity leave from the budget session of the Lok Sabha